

When the stars align

The Champions League matches so far have been determined by exceptional performances from a few **standout players.**

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This has been Raphinha's season. Period.

The Brazilian (**below**) has been a late bloomer, developing in Portugal, France, and England, but his purple patch arrived in the 2024-25 season at Barcelona.

Raphinha had struggled to get going for Barca in the Champions League in his first two seasons (three goals, six assists). But this season, he has scored nine goals and assisted six more to become his club's most lethal weapon along the flanks.

Since the start of 2024, Raphinha has been directly involved in more UEFA Champions League goals than any other player (17 in 13 appearances — 12 goals, five assists).

He seems to have made Benfica his favourite opponent, scoring goals at crucial times and at regular intervals.

Against the Portuguese top-flight side in January, Raphinha scored the winning goal in second-half stoppage time to secure

Barcelona's spot in the round of 16. In the next round, with Barca outnumbered, it

was the flying Brazilian who came to its rescue, scoring after the hour mark, a goal that proved to be the winner.

Elsewhere, Brahim Diaz and Harvey Elliott played rescue acts for Real Madrid and Liverpool, respectively. Arne Slot's men, who have dominated the Premier League this season, were kept under the cosh by Paris Saint-Germain for 87 minutes until Elliott ended a swift counterattack into the net, giving the Reds a slender advantage.

Meanwhile, Real Madrid took a leaf out of Atletico Madrid's book to gain an upper hand over its city rival in the Champions League. A former Manchester City player had scored in the previous Madrid derby, which had ended 1-1, with Atletico's scorer being Julian Alvarez.

In a different competition, a month later, another former City player spoiled Atletico's party, not with a draw but with a 2-1 win as Diaz netted the winner, making full use of the chance he got as Jude Bellingham's replacement, who was suspended.

Some of the other games in the first leg of this round ended predictably in favour of the stronger teams on paper: Aston Villa beating Club Brugge 3-1 and Inter Milan pipping Feyenoord 2-0.

Also, Arsenal hammered seven goals against a meek PSV Eindhoven to become the first team in UEFA Champions League history to score seven or more goals away from home in a knockout-stage match.

Meanwhile, it was box-office drama in the games involving the German teams.

LOSC Lille held Dortmund to a 1-1 draw with its first shot on target, from Hakon Haraldsson, while Xabi Alonso's men lost 0-3 to Bayern, their first loss to the Bavarians in over four years.

Of the 16 teams in contention, the Gunners look set for the quarterfinals. However, half of the matches in this round have a deficit of one or fewer goals, making the return legs extremely crucial.

As of March 10, both finalists of last season — Real Madrid and Borussia Dortmund — are still in the running. It remains to be seen if they can set up a consecutive final, since both of them are on opposite sides of the competition.

